

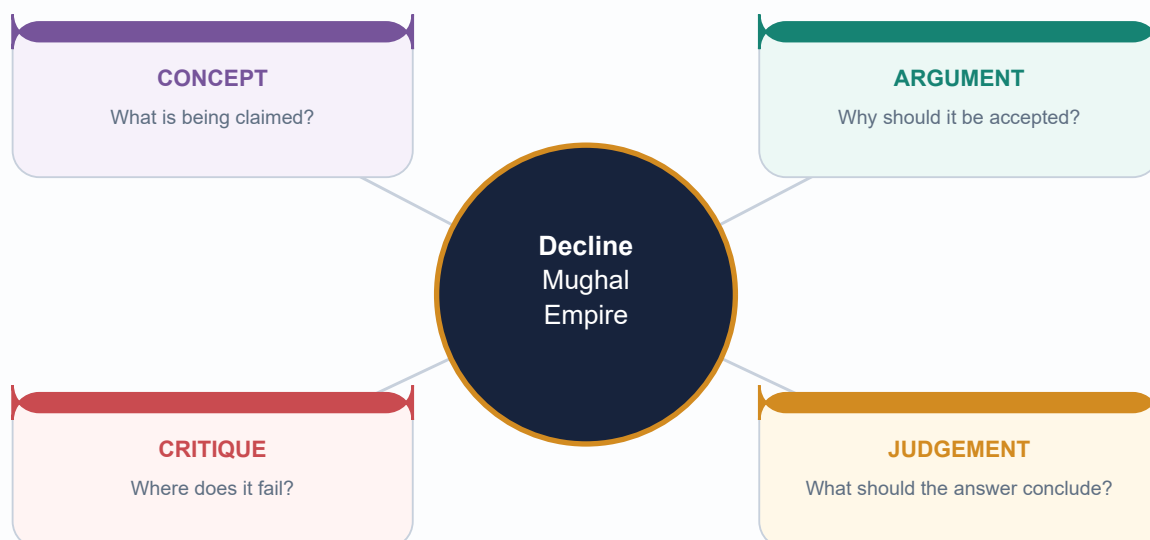
UPSC MODERN INDIAN HISTORY WORKBOOK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) Solved-Practice Workbook

Subject: Modern Indian History | Paper: GS-I

Eight source-trap MCQs with strict A -> B -> C -> D rotation

Original 10-, 15- and 20-mark solved content frameworks



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Topic-Specific MCQ Loop 1

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Each question is generated from an explicit source-chapter trap and explanation.

STATIC THEORY

- Q1. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "The empire collapsed immediately in 1707."?

- A. It **fragmented gradually** over decades; the emperor remained a symbolic figure into the 19th century.

- B. The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.

- C. Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.

- D. The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.

- ANSWER: A - It **fragmented gradually** over decades; the emperor remained a symbolic figure into the 19th century.

- Q2. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India."?

- A. Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.

- B. He **plundered and left**; he did not annex the empire.

- C. The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.

- D. Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.

- ANSWER: B - He **plundered and left**; he did not annex the empire.

- Q3. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "The Sayyid Brothers were emperors."?

- A. The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.

- B. Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.

- C. They were **powerful nobles/king-makers**, not rulers.

- D. 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant.

- ANSWER: C - They were **powerful nobles/king-makers**, not rulers.

- Q4. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence."?

- A. Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.

- B. 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant.

- C. The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption.

- D. They became **autonomous in practice** while nominally acknowledging the emperor.

- ANSWER: D - They became **autonomous in practice** while nominally acknowledging the emperor.

MEMORY HOOK

Resolve the misconception before memorising the fact.

MAINS ANGLE**STUDY LINK**

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) -> Source-grounded practice

HIGH**Topic-Specific MCQ Loop 2****GS-I Modern
Indian History****INTRO & ORIGIN**

Each question is generated from an explicit source-chapter trap and explanation.

STATIC THEORY

- Q5. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant."?

- A. Regional economies and states (Bengal, Awadh, Marathas) were often **vibrant**; "decline" was of the *centre*.
- B. 18th-century India was uniformly decadent and stagnant.
- C. The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption.
- D. Provincial governors declared full independence.

- ANSWER: A - Regional economies and states (Bengal, Awadh, Marathas) were often **vibrant**; "decline" was of the *centre*.

- Q6. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption."?

- A. The jagirdari crisis was simply corruption.
- B. It was a **structural mismatch** between the number of claimants and revenue-yielding assignments.
- C. Provincial governors declared full independence.
- D. Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline.

- ANSWER: B - It was a **structural mismatch** between the number of claimants and revenue-yielding assignments.

- Q7. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Provincial governors declared full independence."?

- A. Provincial governors declared full independence.
- B. Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline.
- C. They kept the **legal fiction** of Mughal sovereignty (coins/khutba in the emperor's name).
- D. The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.

- ANSWER: C - They kept the **legal fiction** of Mughal sovereignty (coins/khutba in the emperor's name).

- Q8. Which statement correctly resolves this common misconception: "Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline."?

- A. Nadir Shah's and Abdali's invasions *caused* the decline.
- B. The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.
- C. Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.
- D. They **accelerated and exposed** a decline that was already structural.

- ANSWER: D - They **accelerated and exposed** a decline that was already structural.

MEMORY HOOK

Resolve the misconception before memorising the fact.

MAINS ANGLE

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire
(1707–1740s) -> Source-grounded practice

HIGH

Solved 10-Mark PracticeGS-I Modern
Indian History**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Explain The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) with reference to its concepts, applications and limitations.

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE**1. Concept**

Define the exact scope and terminology.

V

2. Core analysis

Organise the source content into two or three dimensions.

V

3. Evidence

Use the chapter's India-centric examples or chronology.

V

4. Critical layer

Add traps, limitations, counter-view or implementation constraints.

V

5. Judgement

Conclude in direct response to the directive.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
- □ **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
- □ During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
- □ **Nadir Shah** of Persia invaded in **1739**, defeated the Mughals at **Karnal**, sacked Delhi and took away enormous plunder including the **Peacock Throne** and the **Kohinoor** — a shattering blow to Mughal prestige.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** (Nadir Shah's successor) invaded India repeatedly between **1748 and 1761**, further draining the empire and culminating in the **Third Battle of Panipat (1761)**.
- □ **Aurangzeb died in 1707**; decline dates from the wars of succession that followed.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan, Husain Ali) were the "**king-makers**".
- □ **Nadir Shah** defeated the Mughals at **Karnal (1739)**, sacked Delhi, took the **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor**.
- □ **Muhammad Shah (1719–48)** — during his reign Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became autonomous in practice.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invaded India several times, **1748–1761**.
- □□ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.
- □□ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne)**. The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag □ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
- □□ "The decline of the Mughal Empire was rooted in internal structural weaknesses; foreign invasions only exposed them." Critically examine.
- □□ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.

MAINS ANGLE

These are model content points; arrange them into paragraphs rather than reproducing a list.

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) -> 10-mark answer

HIGH

Solved 15-Mark Practice

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Analyse The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) with reference to its concepts, applications and limitations.

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE**1. Concept**

Define the exact scope and terminology.

V

2. Core analysis

Organise the source content into two or three dimensions.

V

3. Evidence

Use the chapter's India-centric examples or chronology.

V

4. Critical layer

Add traps, limitations, counter-view or implementation constraints.

V

5. Judgement

Conclude in direct response to the directive.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
- □ **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
- □ During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
- □ **Nadir Shah** of Persia invaded in **1739**, defeated the Mughals at **Karnal**, sacked Delhi and took away enormous plunder including the **Peacock Throne** and the **Kohinoor** — a shattering blow to Mughal prestige.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** (Nadir Shah's successor) invaded India repeatedly between **1748 and 1761**, further draining the empire and culminating in the **Third Battle of Panipat (1761)**.
- □ **Aurangzeb died in 1707**; decline dates from the wars of succession that followed.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan, Husain Ali) were the "**king-makers**".
- □ **Nadir Shah** defeated the Mughals at **Karnal (1739)**, sacked Delhi, took the **Peacock Throne & Kohinoor**.
- □ **Muhammad Shah (1719–48)** — during his reign Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became autonomous in practice.
- □ **Ahmad Shah Abdali** invaded India several times, **1748–1761**.
- □□ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.
- □□ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne)**. The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag □ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
- □□ "The decline of the Mughal Empire was rooted in internal structural weaknesses; foreign invasions only exposed them." Critically examine.
- □□ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.

MAINS ANGLE

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STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) -> 15-mark answer

HIGH

Solved 20-Mark Practice

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Critically examine The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) with reference to its concepts, applications and limitations.

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE**1. Concept**

Define the exact scope and terminology.

V

2. Core analysis

Organise the source content into two or three dimensions.

V

3. Evidence

Use the chapter's India-centric examples or chronology.

V

4. Critical layer

Add traps, limitations, counter-view or implementation constraints.

V

5. Judgement

Conclude in direct response to the directive.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
- □ **Bahadur Shah I (1707–12)** followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
- □ The **Sayyid Brothers** (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "**king-makers**" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.
- □ During **Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48)**, court factionalism continued and provinces such as **Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh** became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.
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- □□ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne)**. The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag □ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
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- □□ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.

MAINS ANGLE

These are model content points; arrange them into paragraphs rather than reproducing a list.

STUDY LINK

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s) -> 20-mark answer

HIGH

Workbook Rapid Revision

GS-I Modern
Indian History

INTRO & ORIGIN

Final revision is placed after teaching and solved practice.

TOPIC RECALL MAP

The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s)

V

Definition □ Aurangzeb's death in 1707 was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.	Mechanism □ Bahadur Shah I (1707–12) followed a policy of compromise with Marathas, Rajputs and Sikhs, but reversed nothing fundamental; after him a series of weak rulers depended on powerful nobles.
Application □ The Sayyid Brothers (Abdullah Khan & Husain Ali) became "king-makers" — raising and deposing emperors (Farrukhsiyar) — showing that the throne had become a prize for court factions.	Evaluation □ During Muhammad Shah's long reign (1719–48), court factionalism continued and provinces such as Hyderabad, Bengal and Awadh became effectively autonomous. His sobriquet "Rangila" should not substitute for structural explanation.

STATIC THEORY

- □ Aurangzeb's death in **1707** was followed by wars of succession and a rapid weakening of central authority; weak successors could not hold the vast empire together.
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- □ □ The three great regional powers rising from the ruins: **Marathas, Sikhs, Jats**, plus autonomous provinces.

MEMORY HOOK

Meaning -> mechanism -> evidence -> limitation -> judgement

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. ☐ ☐ **Repatriation & heritage debates around Mughal-era loot (Kohinoor, Peacock Throne).** The Kohinoor — carried off by Nadir Shah in 1739 and later acquired by the British — is a recurring subject in India's cultural-repatriation discourse. Relevance: connects 18th-century plunder to present-day debates on the return of looted artefacts (a live GS-1 art-&culture / GS-2 diplomacy hook). (Tag ☐ *when pegged to a specific verified news item.*)
2. ☐ ☐ "The decline of the Mughal Empire was rooted in internal structural weaknesses; foreign invasions only exposed them." Critically examine.
3. ☐ ☐ Assess the role of the **jagirdari crisis** and factional court politics in the disintegration of Mughal authority.
4. ☐ ☐ How did the political vacuum of the 18th century shape the rise of regional states and the eventual **British ascendancy**?
5. ☐ Bipin Chandra frames decline as **structural**, not merely a matter of "bad kings": the **jagirdari and agrarian crisis** was central. The number of nobles (mansabdars) and their claims outran the supply of revenue-yielding **jagirs**, producing a scramble (*be-jagiri*) that turned the nobility inward against itself and against the peasantry.
6. ☐ ☐ Historiography (context to know): **Satish Chandra** located the crisis in the jagirdari–agrarian system; **Irfan Habib** stressed the **agrarian crisis** (over-exploitation of peasants driving revolts); the **Aligarh school** emphasised systemic economic strain, while a **regional/"revisionist" view** (Muzaffar Alam, C.A. Bayly) reframed 18th-century "decline" as a **shift of power and prosperity to the regions**, not universal collapse.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** The empire collapsed immediately in 1707.
- CORRECT:** It **fragmented gradually** over decades; the emperor remained a symbolic figure into the 19th century.
- WRONG:** Nadir Shah established Persian rule in India.
- CORRECT:** He **plundered and left**; he did not annex the empire.
- WRONG:** The Sayyid Brothers were emperors.
- CORRECT:** They were **powerful nobles/king-makers**, not rulers.
- WRONG:** Awadh, Bengal and Hyderabad formally declared independence.
- CORRECT:** They became **autonomous in practice** while nominally acknowledging the emperor.

MAINS ANGLE

Use *The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s)* as an argument, not as an unstructured list of facts.

STUDY LINK

Modern Indian History -> The Decline of the Mughal Empire (1707–1740s)